Chapter Five

A Gigantic Drum, 1922–1923

As the year 1922 dawned, Britain's position in southern Asia was a far cry from what Curzon had envisioned in 1918. Between 1919 and 1922 things had appeared to go from bad to worse for the foreign secretary. In Persia the 1919 agreement had proved a highly embarrassing failure, matched only by apparent British impotence in preventing the Bolshevik regime establishing its influence in the country. When it came to Afghanistan, Britain had also been unable to exert its authority to retain hold of Kabul's foreign relations or negotiate an exclusive treaty at the expense of Russia. The Anglo-Soviet Trade Agreement had been completed in spite of Curzon's objections, and his attempt to bring Moscow to task over its violations of the agreement had left him red in the face. Even Britain's policy towards Turkey had proved a mistake, contributing as it did to the impetus of the nationalist movement there. When Persia, Turkey and Afghanistan decided in 1921 to sign diplomatic agreements with Soviet Russia, it seemed that all of Curzon's worse fears had come true – Britain's patronage had been rejected for the friendship of the revolutionary upstarts now governing Russia. As Britain slunk away from its 1918 position of optimism, Curzon meanwhile reacted by throwing tantrums at the Persians, the Russians, the Indian government, Winston Churchill and anyone else who happened to cross him.

And yet, as this chapter will show, there were actually many reasons for London and Delhi to remain cheerful. While things may not have developed exactly as Curzon had planned, neither had they turned out as bad as the foreign secretary had predicted. For one thing, despite all his anti-Bolshevik rhetoric, the exposure of Afghanistan and Persia to Bolshevism proved far from fatal for the native governments. For although Whitehall had made its fair share of mistakes in its handling of Asian nationalism and Muslim discontent, the Soviet government had been committing its own blunders